BY ORDER OF THE COMMANDER
14 FLYING TRAINING WING (AETC)

COLUMBUS AIR FORCE BASE
INSTRUCTION 36-2503

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Personnel

COLUMBUS AFB BELOW THE ZONE (BTZ) GUIDANCE

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(CMSgt Todd R. Rosenzweig)
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This publication implements and extends the guidance of DAFI 36-2502, *Enlisted Airman Promotion/Demotion Program,* and applies to all units and tenants at Columbus. It establishes SrA BTZ administrative procedures for the Central Base Board (CBB). It applies to all United States Air Force (USAF) units that have personnel under the promotion authority of the 14th Force Support Squadron (FSS). This publication does not apply to Air Force Reserve Command (AFRC) Units. This publication does not apply to the Air National Guard (ANG). Ensure that all records created because of processes prescribed in this publication are maintained IAW Air Force Instruction 33-322, Management of Records, and disposed of IAW Air Force Records Information Management System (AFRIMS) Records Disposition Schedule (RDS). Contact supporting records managers as required. This publication requires the collection and or maintenance of information protected by the Privacy Act (PA) of 1974 authorized by Department of Defense Instruction (DoDI) 5400.11 DoD Privacy and Civil Liberties Programs. Refer recommended changes and questions about this publication to the Office of Primary Responsibility (OPR) using the DAF Form 847, Recommendation for Change of Publication; route DAF Form 847s from the field through the appropriate functional's chain of command.

1. Overview. The Senior Airman (SrA) Below the Zone (BTZ) promotion program provides a one-time consideration for early promotion. The program provides exceptionally well qualified Airmen First Class (A1C) to be considered for promotion six months prior to the fully qualified point of promotion. Selection opportunity is 15 percent of the total time-in-grade (TIG) and time-in-service (TIS) eligible population. AFPC/DPSOE publishes additional program guidance.

2. Eligibility. Airmen must meet promotion requirements established in AFI 36-2502, Table 2.1. Individuals nominated must be of the highest caliber and clearly deserve the recognition. Commanders will "pre-screen" all eligible members for negative "quality force" indicators.

2.1. Unit commanders will ensure non-recommended Airmen are notified either verbally or in writing if they are non-recommended for SrA BTZ.

3. Program Responsibilities.

3.1. **Columbus AFB Wing Commander or designated representative** : Serves as promotion authority for the wing Central Base Board (CBB).

3.1.1. Establishes written administrative procedures for the Senior Airman BTZ Promotion Program.

3.1.2. Establishes a timeline for the CBB and large unit boards to make selections.

3.1.3. Approves quota distribution based on the percentages of eligible members. Approval of quota distribution is delegated to 14 FSS/FSDP, and IAW AFI 36-2502, 2.3.5.

3.1.4. Establishes the SrA BTZ result release date for large boards and the CBB.

3.1.5. Notifies members selected by the CBB or delegates authority.

3.2. **Columbus AFB Command Chief Master Sergeant (CCC) or designated Chief Master Sergeant** : Serves as the CBB President and oversees the CBB and large unit process.

3.2.1. Selects a minimum of four, but no more than five, CBB members. Convenes and chairs the CBB.

3.2.2. Determines whether a "face-to-face" board or a "records only" board will convene for the CBB and large unit boards.

3.2.3. Ensures CBB and large unit board members are briefed and follow CBB instructions.

3.2.4. Is a non-voting member on the CBB unless there is a tie; then serves as the tie-breaking authority.

3.2.5. Ensures each individual is scored using a fair and consistent scoring system.

3.2.6. Oversees preparation of the CBB board report signed by the board president and 14 FTW/CC.

3.3. **Military Personnel Flight** - Career Development (14 FSS/FSDP).

3.3.1. Administers SrA BTZ Promotion Program IAW AFI 36-2502 and current Air Force Personnel Center guidance.

3.3.2. Appoints a board recorder for the CBB.

3.3.3. Determines quotas and distribution based on 15 percent of eligible Airmen. Eligible Airmen must meet minimum TIS and TIG requirements.

3.3.4. Distributes SrA BTZ quotas each quarter to the CBB and large units by the 15th of the first processing month.

3.3.5. Publishes policy for BTZ procedures.

3.4. **Unit Commander** :

3.4.1. Reviews the Eligibility Listing provided by 14 FSS Career Development to consider all individuals meeting TIS and TIG requirements. If a member is on temporary duty, deployed, or on emergency leave, or has a report no later than date on or after the first day of the first processing month, the unit commander will ensure the member is considered for that quarter's selections. If the member is a projected gain and has not departed the previous duty station as of the first day of the first month of that SrA BTZ quarter, the gaining unit and MPF in coordination with the current unit commander must ensure the member is considered at previous location.

3.4.2. Ensures all eligible members meeting the TIS and TIG requirements are informed of their eligibility by verifying member's personal data via a Report on Individual Person sent by 14 FSS/FSDP Career Development.

3.4.3. Nominates unit member(s) to meet a large unit board or CBB based on the following criteria:

3.4.3.1. Airman demonstrates the potential to be effective as a SrA and is clearly deserving of promotion above his/her peers.

3.4.3.2. Airman does not have negative quality indicators, or any promotion ineligibility condition listed in AFI 36-2502, Table 1.1.

3.4.3.3. Review of any closed out enlisted performance briefing, completed DAF Form 1206, his/her Personal Information File (if available), decorations, and discuss nomination with the member's supervisors/rating chain prior to making a nomination decision.

4. Quotas. Quotas are based on 15 percent of the total TIG and TIS eligible population listed on Parts I, II, and III of the quarterly SrA BTZ roster (see **Table 4.1**.).

4.1. The MPF Chief approves and distributes quotas to units. Quotas are computed and distributed as follows:

4.1.1. Computation: Eligibles multiplied by 15 percent equals the quota (Example: 13 eligibles x 0.15 = 1.95 or 2 SrA BTZ quotas (Note: Fractions of 0.5 + are rounded up))

Table 1. Distribution.

ELIQ QUOTA	ELIQ QUOTA	ELIQ QUOTA	ELIQ QUOTA
2-6 / 1	7-9 / 2	10–16 / 3	17-23 / 4

*In cases where there are no large units and there are only 2-6 eligibles from all the small units, the base is authorized to hold a CBB and allowed 1-quota.

Table 2. Processing Cycles.

PROCESSING MONTHS	SELECTION MONTH	PROMOTION MONTHS
JAN – FEB	MAR	APR - JUN
APR – MAY	JUN	JUL - SEP
JUL – AUG	SEP	OCT - DEC
OCT – NOV	DEC	JAN - MAR

5. BTZ Nomination Procedures. For those meeting the CBB, commanders must provide 14 FSS/FSDP, Career Development an AF IMT 1206 that consists of 5 performance statements with a maximum of 10 lines, single-spaced statements not including topic headings. The AF IMT 1206 will also include whether the member is available to meet the CBB if a face-to-face board is held. Commanders will submit an airman's decorations with the Nomination for Award.

5.1. For large units, commanders will develop procedures for submitting nominations.

5.2. AF IMT 1206 will consist of the following heading: EXECUTING THE MISSION AND MANAGING RESOURCES (10 lines)

6. Selection/Nomination Folders. Selection/nomination folders will be electronic, reviewed by group Senior Enlisted Leaders (SELs) prior to submission, and will contain the following items in a single PDF with the exception of the awards package key which will be its own separate document:

6.1. BTZ Awards Package Key listing all nominees (separate PDF attachment)

6.2. Military Personnel Data System generated BTZ Record on Individual Person

6.3. DAF Form 1206

6.4. Member's Single Unit Retrieval Format (SURF)

6.5. Physical Fitness Assessment (PFA) history print out

6.6. Decoration citations (if applicable)

6.7. Large units are responsible for creating their own electronic selection folders.

6.8. An approved decoration may be filed in an individual's record at any time up until the date of the board. Supplemental consideration will not be given because a decoration was not approved or placed in the record when the board convened.

7. Large Units Procedures. Large units (squadrons with seven or more eligible) will receive their own quotas and make selections at the unit level.

7.1. Selection boards will conform to the same standards established for the CBB. The board will be held no later than the last day of the selection month.

7.2. Large unit commanders will hold a records board and may conduct an optional face-to-face board to select the most qualified individuals for SrA BTZ. The review process must be fair and equitable for all individuals.

7.3. The board president and board recorder will ensure board members are briefed on the Air Force and Columbus AFB BTZ policies.

7.4. If a face-to-face board is held, nominees will wear service dress.

7.5. Once the board adjourns, the convening commander must provide the Large Unit Board Results, and the signed unit BTZ Eligibility MFR to 14 FSS/FSDP, Career Development no later than the last duty day of the selection month. A unit is not required to use all quotas if the quality of the nominations is not sufficient to warrant it. If any quotas are not used, indicate by annotating the roster before returning to the MPF. Commanders may notify selectees/non-selectees of their status either verbally or in writing on the Columbus AFB/CC's approved release date.

8. Small Unit Procedures. Small Units (squadrons with six or less eligible) are combined into one pool of eligibles to compete at the CBB. However, small units are not required to submit a nominee if those eligible are not of the highest caliber and clearly deserve the recognition. If the unit decides not to nominate any eligibles, please advise the 14 FSS/FSDP, Career Development by annotating the BTZ Eligibility Memorandum for Record (MFR) accordingly.

8.1. Selection/Nomination folders that are not received by the MPF by the suspense date annotated on the unit BTZ Eligibility MFR will not be accepted or be eligible for supplemental consideration. Unit commanders must request a formal exception to policy to submit late nomination folders, through their group SEL, to the Columbus AFB/CCC. All units pursuing an exception to policy must notify 14 FSS/FSDP.

8.2. Selection/nomination folders will be electronic, reviewed by group SELs prior to submission, and will contain the following items in a single PDF with the exception of the awards package key which will be its own separate document:

8.2.1. BTZ Awards Package Key listing all nominees (separate PDF attachment)

8.2.2. Military Personnel Data System generated BTZ Record on Individual Person

8.2.3. DAF Form 1206

8.2.4. Member's SURF

8.2.5. PFA history print out

8.2.6. Decoration citations (if applicable)

8.3. Unit commanders will use the SrA BTZ Eligibility MFR and an appropriate evaluation process to determine nominee for the CBB. Unit commanders will underline the name of the nominee on the eligibility list, sign the list, and return it to 14 FSS/FSDP, Enlisted Promotions NLT the suspense date annotated on the unit BTZ Eligibility MFR.

8.4. Unit Commander's may nominate up to the maximum number of available allocations to the CBB. Unit commanders should ensure only those of the highest caliber and clearly deserve the recognition are submitted as a nominee. *(Example: If the CBB has 2 allocations then each group can send up to 2 nominees).*

8.5. The CBB will conduct a records board and may conduct an optional face-to-face board to select the most qualified individuals for SrA BTZ. The review process must be fair and equitable for all individuals. If a face-to-face board is held, nominees will be required to be present; unless a nominee is TDY, deployed, or on emergency leave (as defined in AFI 36-3003).

8.5.1. If a face-to-face board is held, nominees and board members will wear service dress.

8.6. Return the signed CBB Results to 14 FSS/FSDP, Enlisted Promotions no later than the last day of the selection month.

9. Board Composition. The CBB will consist of the CCC or designated Chief appointed by the Columbus AFB/CCC, four to five board members (selected by the Columbus AFB/CCC or designated Chief), and a board recorder. The Columbus AFB/CCC or appointed Chief will be the board president.

9.1. The large unit board will consist of the board president (Chief Master Sergeant if available), four to five board members, and a board recorder. In the event a Chief Master Sergeant is unavailable, the board president will be the next highest-ranking member.

10. Board President Responsibilities. Board president will be familiar with AFI 36-2502 and this instruction to ensure instructions/procedures are strictly followed during the BTZ board and oversee board operations.

10.1. Ensures the fair and equitable consideration of each nominee. The DAF Form 1206 will be used to evaluate the following factors: EXECUTING THE MISSION AND MANAGING RESOURCES (10 lines max).

10.2. In the event there is a tie between Airmen, the board president will be the tie- breaking authority.

10.3. The president manages the board and can decide to discuss and resolve differences in rankings. Only discussion in regard to the content of the selection package will be allowed. The president is the final deciding authority.

11. Board Members Responsibilities. Board members will be familiar with AFI 36-2502 and ensure strict adherence to this instruction during BTZ Board.

11.1. Once board members receive selection folders they will not forward, discuss or ask questions to or with anyone other than the board president or MPF representative.

11.2. Only discussion in regard to the content of the selection package will be allowed.

11.3. Grade each selection folder individually, then rank all packages with 1 being the best.

12. Board Recorder Responsibilities. Ensures each board member receives complete selection folders on each nominee submitted for BTZ Board.

12.1. The board recorder will record each board member’s score and rank of each nominee. Ranking of each nominee will be tallied for an overall ranking.

13. Scoring Scale/Selection Procedures. Each nominee is evaluated based upon facts contained in the selection folder. Board members will score each individual separately.

14. Announcing Selections. The 14 FTW/CC approves CBB selections and will make notifications at his/her discretion.

14.1. Commanders of large units make their selections and will notify selectees of his/ her status on the 14 FTW/CC approved release date.

JUSTIN T. GRIEVE, Colonel, USAF
Commander

Attachment 1

GLOSSARY OF REFERENCES AND SUPPORTING INFORMATION

References

DAFPD 36-25, *Military Promotion and Demotion*, 14 December 2022

DAFI 36-2502, *Enlisted Airman Promotion/Demotion Programs*, 16 January 2024

AFI 36-2406, *Officer and Enlisted Evaluation Systems,* 8 November 2016

AFI 33-322, *Records Management and Information Governance Program*, 27 July 2021

Prescribed Forms

None

Adopted Forms

DAF Form 847, *Recommendation for Change of Publication*

DAF Form 1206, *Nomination for Award*

Abbreviations and Acronyms

A1C—Airmen First Class

BTZ—Below the Zone

CBB—Central Base Board

CC—Commander

CCC—Command Chief Master Sergeant

MFR—Memorandum for Record

PFA—Physical Fitness Assessment

SEL—Senior Enlisted Leader

SrA—Senior Airman

SURF—Single Unit Retrieval Format